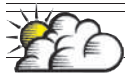


The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

RE V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny 60/36 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 57/45 B18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 7, 2026 • \$4

Trump sets slim GOP priorities before Nov.

President insists he'll be impeached if Democrats take control of Congress

BY EMILY DAVIES, MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR AND CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

President Donald Trump on Tuesday warned that Democrats would “find a reason to impeach me” if the GOP lost control of Congress — using the prediction to pressure lawmakers to unify behind a narrow set of electoral priorities to win the 2026 mid-term elections.

“You got to win the midterms, because if we don’t win the midterms, they’ll find a reason to impeach me,” Trump said. “I’ll get impeached.”

The remark was a rare acknowledgment of Trump’s political vulnerability as Republicans prepare to face a Democratic Party buoyed by a string of off-year election victories, favorable polling and voter anxiety over an economy now fully under Trump’s stewardship. The warning framed the midterms not only as a referendum on his agenda, but as a test of his legacy.

Trump addressed the representatives at the start of an all-day policy forum for House Republicans inside the Kennedy Center, a performing arts building recently renamed in his honor. The setting in the heart of Washington underscored how far Trump has come since Jan. 6, 2021, exactly five years ago, when rioters stormed the Capitol and set off years of criminal prosecution and politi-

SEE TRUMP ON A4

CDC staff ‘blindsided’ on vaccine guidelines

Experts: RFK Jr. deputy unilaterally narrowed childhood shot protocols

BY LENA H. SUN

Vaccine experts at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention were blindsided by a top deputy to Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s decision to unilaterally overhaul the childhood immunization schedule, according to current and former agency staff.

U.S. health officials took the unprecedented action Monday to narrow the list of vaccines that the federal government routinely recommends for all children, a shift that leading public health experts and medical organizations warned could weaken protections against preventable deadly diseases.

The change, which took effect immediately, means the CDC no longer broadly recommends immunization for influenza, rotavirus, hepatitis A and certain meningococcal diseases that cause meningitis. Instead, these vaccinations will be advised only for smaller groups of children and babies considered at higher risk or if a doctor recommends it. Trump administration health officials said the revised schedule more

SEE CDC ON A2



FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

BY MARÍA LUISA PAÚL

For a brief moment, some Venezuelans allowed themselves to celebrate.

When they learned Saturday that strongman Nicolás Maduro had been seized by U.S. Special Forces, many group chats filled with messages of joy and relief. Some people cried. One family in Caracas opened a bottle of champagne they had bought months earlier and saved for a special occasion. After more than a decade of living under Maduro, there were cautious hopes for a different future.

By Monday, however, those feelings had been replaced by more familiar ones: fear, dread and uncertainty.

Venezuela’s government has moved quickly to suppress any public expression of support for Maduro’s ouster, launching a nationwide crackdown that has in-

Fear in Caracas amid new wave of repression

Venezuela’s government has quickly suppressed support for Maduro’s removal with detentions, arrests and armed gangs

A woman walked by a peeling mural of Venezuelan independence leader Simón Bolívar in Caracas on Monday. A tense, eerie quiet has taken hold in the capital.

cluded the detention of journalists, the arrest of civilians and the deployment of armed gangs across the capital.

“It feels like it did after the presidential elections in 2024,” said María, 55, who like others in this story spoke on the condition that they be identified by their first name, or on the condition of anonymity, for fear of reprisals. “We won, but we also lost,” she said, referring to the country’s last elections, in which Maduro claimed victory despite tallies showing the opposition had prevailed.

The crackdown unfolded as Delcy Rodríguez, the country’s vice president, was sworn in as interim president Monday at the National Assembly. Senior military officials publicly pledged their loyalty to her — a signal that while the country had a new leader, the old power structure

SEE REPRESSION ON A13

Raid on Maduro killed about 75

VENEZUELAN, CUBAN FORCES AMONG DEAD

No American fatalities, U.S. officials reaffirm

BY DAN LAMOTHE AND JOHN HUDSON

The U.S. government assesses that about 75 people were killed during Saturday’s military raid to capture Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, including dozens of fatalities that resulted from a gun battle at his compound in Caracas, according to officials familiar with the matter.

One person said that at least 67 people were killed in the predawn strike, while another said that about 75 to 80 people were left dead. The officials, who like others spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the issue’s sensitivity, said the assessments account for Venezuelan and Cuban security forces as well as civilians caught in the fray. The figures roughly match an estimate that Venezuelan officials have shared in recent days.

The sizable death toll adds meaning to President Donald Trump’s public remarks that the operation he approved was “effective” but “very violent.”

About a half-dozen U.S. troops were injured in the operation, with some suffering gunshot wounds in the firefight at Maduro’s compound. Some were transported to Brooke Army

SEE VENEZUELA ON A4

What Americans think

A Post poll finds divided opinions on U.S. actions in Venezuela. A6

Nobel winner: Machado praises Trump and calls for elections. A13

Most damaging CIA traitor in agency history spied for Russia

BY WALTER PINCUS

Aldrich H. Ames, the CIA officer whose spying for Moscow was the most damaging breach in the agency’s history, reportedly causing the deaths of at least 10 recruited CIA or allied intelligence agents, died Jan. 5 at the Federal

Correctional Institution in Cumberland, Maryland. He was 84.

His death was recorded in the Federal Bureau of Prisons’ inmate database, which did not say how he died, and confirmed by a spokesman for the agency.

ALDRICH AMES 1941-2026

“Financial troubles, immediate and continuing,” Mr. Ames said matter-of-factly, were what led him to spy for the Soviet Union and to remain a double agent for nine years, until the moment of his arrest in February 1994. He had continued to spy for Russia

after the dissolution of the Soviet Union in late 1991.

But money, he said, was not the only reason he could justify to himself what became the Central Intelligence Agency’s worst security loss in its then-47-year history.

When Mr. Ames was inter-

SEE AMES ON A2



Aldrich Ames, who spent years as a spy, was sentenced to life in prison with no chance of parole.



JAH CHIKWENDIU/THE WASHINGTON POST

An industry group argues that data centers, such as an Amazon facility in Aldie, Virginia, above, can bring jobs and other benefits. Opposition to such projects could affect midterm elections.

Data center backlash is rewiring red-blue divide

Politically potent anger in communities across the U.S. is snarling billions of dollars in AI projects

BY EVAN HALPER

SAND SPRINGS, OKLA. — One float stood out among the tinsel and holiday cheer at the annual Christmas parade here: an unsightly data center with blinding industrial lights and smoke pouring out of its roof, towering menacingly over a helpless gingerbread house.

This city bordering Tulsa is a battleground, one of many across the country where companies seeking to build massive data centers to win the AI race with China are coming up against the reality of local politics.

Sand Springs leaders were besieged with community anger

after annexing an 827-acre agricultural property miles outside of town and launching into secret talks with a tech giant looking to use it for a sprawling data center. Hundreds of aggrieved voters showed up at community meetings. Swarms of protest signs are taking root along the rural roads.

“It feels like these data center companies have just put a big target on our backs,” said Kyle Schmidt, leader of the newly formed Protect Sand Springs Alliance. “We are all asking: Where are the people we elected who promised to protect us from these big corporations trying to

SEE DATA CENTERS ON A15

IN THE NEWS

Higher learning A digital detox psychology class at Loyola University Maryland in Baltimore aims to help students break free from smartphone dependency. B13

Compass Coffee bankruptcy The D.C.-based chain proposes closing 11 locations around the region amid lawsuits and sluggish sales. B1

THE NATION Congress has four weeks to finalize spending bills and dodge another shutdown. A3
Rep. Doug LaMalfa’s death further narrows the GOP’s razor-thin House majority. A5

THE WORLD China is studying the U.S. operation in Venezuela, which could embolden it to forcefully intervene in its own neighborhood in Taiwan or the South China Sea, analysts said. A7

THE ECONOMY At the CES trade show, standout technology included Uber’s new robotaxi, a nearly \$5,000 smart toilet and a landline phone for kids. A14
To achieve your money goals in the new year, be sure to practice financial forgiveness, writes Michelle Singletary. A14

STYLE For some workout enthusiasts, missed kudos about a gym milestone can be a punch in the gut. B1

SPORTS The Ravens surprisingly part ways with John Harbaugh, and the Commanders will need two new coordinators. B7

THE REGION In Baltimore, once notorious for its crime, homicides fell to a nearly 50-year low last year. B13

FOOD Fiber is being hailed as the new “it” nutrient. But how much do you need, and how can you get more of it in your diet? E1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A14
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A16
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A7

CONTENT © 2026
The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54454

